

openhouse

art & design • ages 5-8

the artiverse book

the art we make – and why



a teacher's companion to every artwork • 25 units

why these artworks – in this order

Every artwork teaches a specific **skill** through a technique a child can genuinely do – running **easiest** → **hardest**, each with a **medium symbol**. This book carries **both** the studio's exemplar pieces **and** real works by working artists (marked **new**), so children see the full range.

	 oil pastel	 watercolour/tempera	 acrylic	 mixed media	
1		thumbprint art tempera			C&P I&C ●○○○○
2		food oil pastel			S&F C&P ●●○○○
3		lines with watercolour watercolour			L&T ●●○○○
4		leaf printing sunflower tempera			L&T C&P ●●○○○
5		whimsical sun new oil pastel			C&P I&C ●●○○○
6		star with a face new oil pastel			C&P I&C ●●○○○
7		animals oil pastel			S&F C&P ●●●○○
8		warm & cool colours watercolour			C&P B&C ●●●○○
9		shape monsters mixed media			S&F I&C ●●●○○
10		pear collage mixed media			S&F B&C ●●●○○
11		abstract circles acrylic			C&P B&C ●●●○○
12		rainbow art acrylic			C&P ●●●○○
13		fish new oil pastel			S&F C&P ●●●○○
14		two fish new oil pastel			S&F B&C ●●●○○
15		sea creatures new watercolour			C&P S&F ●●●○○
16		whimsical creature new mixed media			S&F I&C ●●●○○

why these artworks – continued

17	 pigeon collage new mixed media	S&F	B&C	●●●●○	
18	 paul klee world mixed media	S&F	B&C	I&C	●●●●○
19	 big fruit & ants mixed media	B&C	S&F	●●●●○	
20	 animals in acrylic acrylic	S&F	C&P	●●●●○	
21	 lemons & oranges acrylic	C&P	B&C	●●●●○	
22	 flower pots acrylic	B&C	C&P	●●●●○	
23	 robots mixed media	S&F	I&C	●●●●○	
24	 eric carle bird new painted-paper collage	C&P	B&C	I&C	●●●●○
25	 firefly & dragonfly acrylic on black paper	C&P	B&C	●●●●●	

skills across the book: line & texture · shape & form · colour & painting · balance & composition · imagination & collaboration – revisited at rising difficulty (the spiral).

a note on the artworks: pieces marked **new** are reference works by independent artists, shown for classroom teaching inspiration only, with thanks – individual artist credits are being added. All other pieces are openhouse studio exemplars. Please don't reproduce or share the reference images outside class.

thumbprint art

tempera

the objective

Press thumb and fingers into paint to discover the marks each one makes, then turn those prints into little creatures.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Fingerprinting – load a fingertip with paint, press cleanly onto paper, and add tiny details on top once dry.

1. Press thumb and fingers into the paint and stamp a row – notice what each finger makes.
2. Turn prints into animals or flowers by grouping them.
3. Add legs, eyes and petals on top with a fine pen.

why it's good for children

Fingerprinting has no skill barrier, so every child succeeds on the first try – and that early success is what makes a child want to keep making. It also builds the very first idea of art: a deliberate **mark** becomes a picture.

how to encourage them

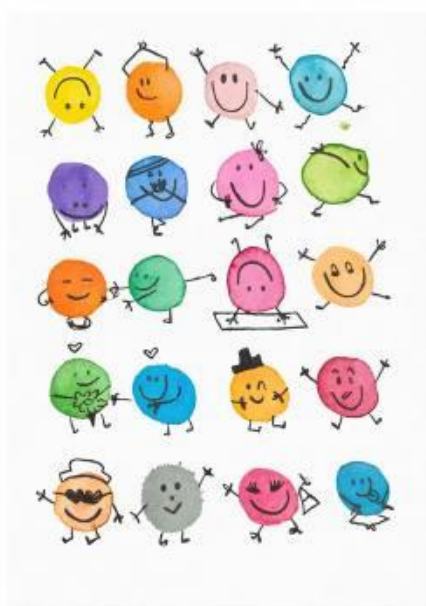
Let them explore the prints freely before making anything. Ask “*what could this little print become?*” – never correct a colour.

materials

tempera paint · paper · a fine pen

where it sits in the spiral

the book's starting point – the first deliberate mark, revisited with more control in every unit after.



what we make – thumbprint animals & flowers

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: fingerprint animals · fingerprint flowers · a fingerprint world I invented

food

oil pastel

the objective

Draw a familiar food from simple shapes and fill it with strong, rich colour, pressing firmly.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Bold fill – draw the food's shape, then press the oil pastel hard to fill it with deep, solid colour.

1. Draw the food as one or two simple shapes.
2. Fill firmly with rich colour, pressing hard.
3. Add a darker edge and small details last.

why it's good for children

Oil pastel gives instant, vivid colour with almost no skill barrier, so children feel successful fast. Drawing a food they love turns a colour exercise into something **personal** – and pressing hard teaches that effort changes how colour looks.

how to encourage them

Ask “*what's your favourite food – can we make it look delicious?*” Model one bold fill, then step back.

materials

oil pastels · cartridge paper

where it sits in the spiral

*the first 'real subject' – shape confidence built here carries into **animals** and beyond.*



what we make – a favourite food

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a fruit I love · a meal I had recently · a food I invented that doesn't exist

lines with watercolour

watercolour

the objective

Make deliberate, clean brush marks – straight, wavy, thick, thin – controlling a loaded brush on purpose.

skills it builds

line & texture

the technique

Brush control – load the brush, then vary pressure and direction to make different line types across the page.

1. Load the brush and pull one clean straight line.
2. Change to wavy, then zig-zag – vary thick and thin.
3. Fill the page with a pattern of different lines.

why it's good for children

Line is the foundation of all drawing and painting. Practising it as a **pattern** (not a picture) lets children focus entirely on **control** – the skill every later unit depends on – while still making something beautiful.

how to encourage them

Name the lines together – “*can you make a sleepy line? a jumpy line?*” Praise control, not neatness.

materials

watercolours · a round brush · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

turns the loose watercolour of the early units into deliberate control the rest of the book builds on.



what we make – a pattern of lines

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a rainbow of lines · a busy city of lines · calm and wavy lines

leaf printing sunflower

tempera

the objective

Press a real leaf into paint and stamp it repeatedly to build a picture from natural texture.

skills it builds

line & texture

colour & painting

the technique

Printing – paint one side of a leaf, press it firmly onto paper, and repeat to build up petals and pattern.

1. Paint the back of a leaf (where the veins show).
2. Press it firmly onto the paper, then lift straight up.
3. Repeat around a centre to build a sunflower.

why it's good for children

Printing brings the **textures of the real world** into art and rewards close looking – children notice the veins of a leaf they'd normally walk past. Repeating one print to build a whole flower quietly introduces **pattern and composition**.

how to encourage them

Collect leaves together first. Ask “*which leaf makes the best petal?*” Let prints overlap.

materials

tempera · real leaves · paper

where it sits in the spiral

extends the mark-making idea into real-world texture; pattern here sets up later composition units.



what we make – a leaf-print sunflower

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a sunflower · a tree in autumn · a leafy jungle

whimsical sun

oil pastel

the objective

Blend warm colours smoothly inside one shape, and give a familiar object a face and a feeling.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Layering & blending oil pastel – press light first, then hard; blend where two colours meet with a fingertip; add the little face last.

1. Draw the sun's round shape and its face.
2. Fill with yellow, pressing harder at the rays.
3. Blend orange into the yellow; add the face and cheeks last.

why it's good for children

Oil pastel gives **instant, rich colour** with almost no skill barrier, so children feel successful straight away. Blending by hand teaches that colours **become** new colours through what the hand does – and giving the sun a face turns a colour exercise into a small act of feeling.

how to encourage them

Ask “*what mood is your sun in today?*” Model one blend, then step back – never correct a colour.

materials

oil pastels · cartridge paper

where it sits in the spiral

the book's warm, confident start – blending returns in every colour unit.



what we make – a sun with its own face

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a sleepy morning sun · a cheeky sun · a proud summer sun

star with a face

oil pastel

the objective

Blend cool colours inside a shape and bring it to life with a character.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Blending & character – fill the star with blended blues and greens, then add a face and cheeks to give it personality.

1. Draw a bold star shape.
2. Fill and blend cool colours inside it.
3. Add a face, cheeks and tiny details last.

why it's good for children

Repeating the blending idea on a new shape **consolidates the skill**, while a character keeps it joyful. Children learn that the same technique makes many different things.

how to encourage them

"What kind of star is this – brave? sleepy?" Celebrate personality over neatness.

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

revisits blending from the sun, now with cool colours.



what we make – a starry little character

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a happy star · a shy star · a shooting star with a face

animals

oil pastel

the objective

Build a recognisable animal from simple shapes, then add marks that describe its fur, feathers or scales.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Shape + texture – start from one big shape for the body, add smaller shapes for head and legs, then layer marks for surface texture.

1. Draw the body as one big shape, add head and legs.
2. Fill with colour, pressing firmly.
3. Add short marks for fur, feathers or scales.

why it's good for children

Animals are a forgiving 'real' subject – a few simple shapes make something recognisable, freeing children to enjoy **colour and texture**. Describing a surface with marks grows the observational habit that deepens all their later work.

how to encourage them

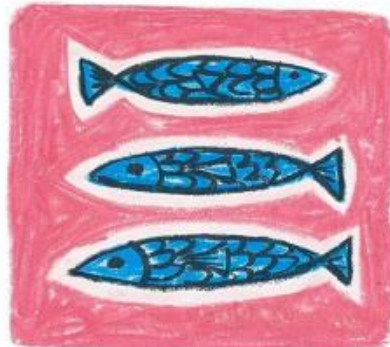
Put a real photo on the table – “*how does its fur lie? which way do the marks go?*” Celebrate character over accuracy.

materials

oil pastels · paper · an animal photo

where it sits in the spiral

brings shape and texture together; the shape confidence here supports every subject that follows.



what we make – an animal

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a pet I know · a wild animal · an animal I invented

warm & cool colours

watercolour

the objective

Mix and place warm colours and cool colours deliberately, and see how they feel different side by side.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Colour theory – group reds/oranges/yellows (warm) and blues/greens/purples (cool), mixing and placing each family on purpose.

1. Mix a set of warm colours, then a set of cool colours.
2. Paint a warm shape and a cool shape side by side.
3. Notice which feels close and which feels far.

why it's good for children

This is the first unit where colour becomes a **deliberate choice**, not just decoration – children learn that colours carry **feeling and depth**. It's a big conceptual step that underpins all later painting and composition.

how to encourage them

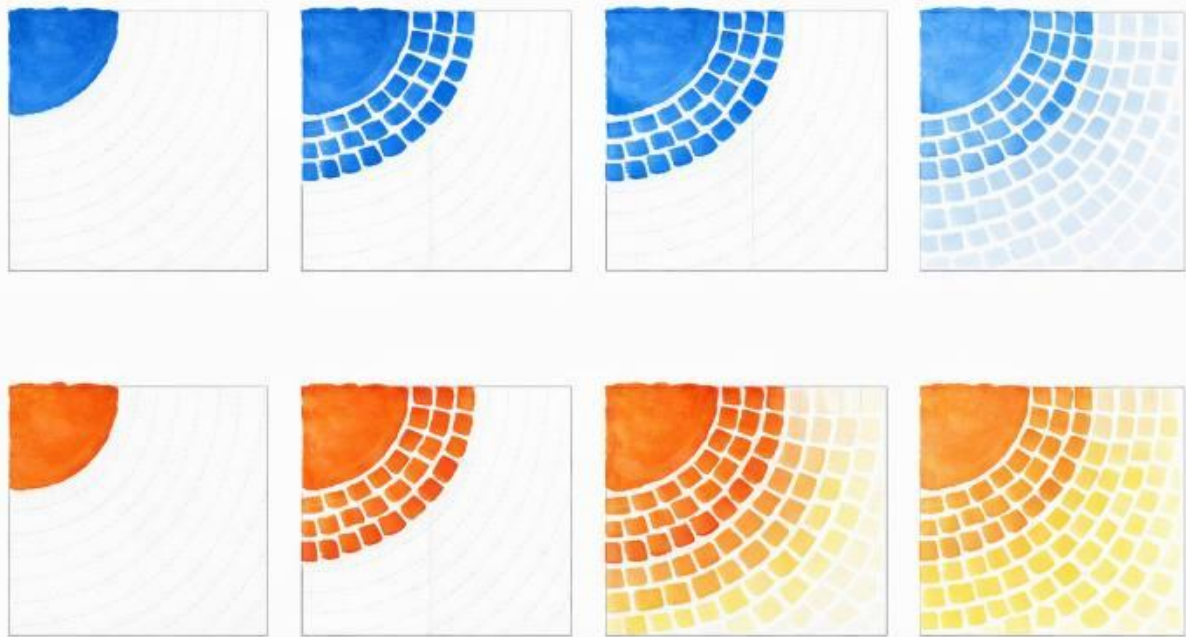
Ask “*which colours feel cosy? which feel cold?*” Let them sort colours before painting.

materials

watercolours · a palette · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

the book's first real colour-theory unit; the warm/cool idea returns in blending and composition later.



what we make – a warm-and-cool study

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a warm sun & a cool moon · fire and ice · a warm and a cool half

shape monsters

mixed media

the objective

Build an imaginary creature by cutting, tearing and assembling shapes – inventing something that doesn't exist.

skills it builds

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Shape play – cut and tear a variety of shapes, then arrange and glue them into a character before adding details.

1. Cut and tear lots of different shapes.
2. Arrange them into a monster – move them before gluing.
3. Glue down, then add eyes, teeth and legs.

why it's good for children

Assembling from shapes lets children **invent** freely without needing to 'draw well', so imagination leads. Deciding where each shape goes is real **composition** – and there's no wrong answer, which builds creative confidence.

how to encourage them

No rules – *"the sillier the better."* Encourage moving shapes around before gluing.

materials

coloured paper · scissors · glue · pens

where it sits in the spiral

shape-and-form meets invention; the arranging skill grows into the composition units that follow.



what we make – a monster from shapes

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a friendly monster · a silly monster · a monster with too many eyes

pear collage

mixed media

the objective

Build a simple still life by layering cut and torn shapes to give a familiar object depth and form.

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

the technique

Collage still life – build the object from layered pieces (light and dark) so it looks rounded, not flat.

1. Tear a pear shape from paper.
2. Add lighter and darker pieces on top for light and shadow.
3. Place it on a simple background.

why it's good for children

Working from a real object grows **observation**, and layering light and dark pieces is a gentle first lesson in **form** – how flat shapes become rounded things. Collage keeps it achievable and tactile.

how to encourage them

Put a real pear on the table. Ask “*where is the light? where is the dark side?*”

materials

coloured paper · scissors · glue · a real pear

where it sits in the spiral

introduces form and light through collage; prepares the fuller still-life painting later.



what we make – a pear still life with depth

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a single pear · a bowl of pears · a pear and its shadow

abstract circles

acrylic

the objective

Mix colours directly on the paper as they're applied, blending wet-into-wet inside circles and shapes.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Wet-into-wet blending – apply one acrylic colour, then a second while it's still wet, and swirl where they meet.

1. Paint a circle in one colour.
2. Add a second colour while wet and blend where they touch.
3. Fill the page with overlapping blended shapes.

why it's good for children

Acrylic blends richly and rewards experimentation, so children discover colour-mixing **by doing** – the most memorable way to learn it. Filling the page with balanced shapes is real **composition** practice, disguised as play.

how to encourage them

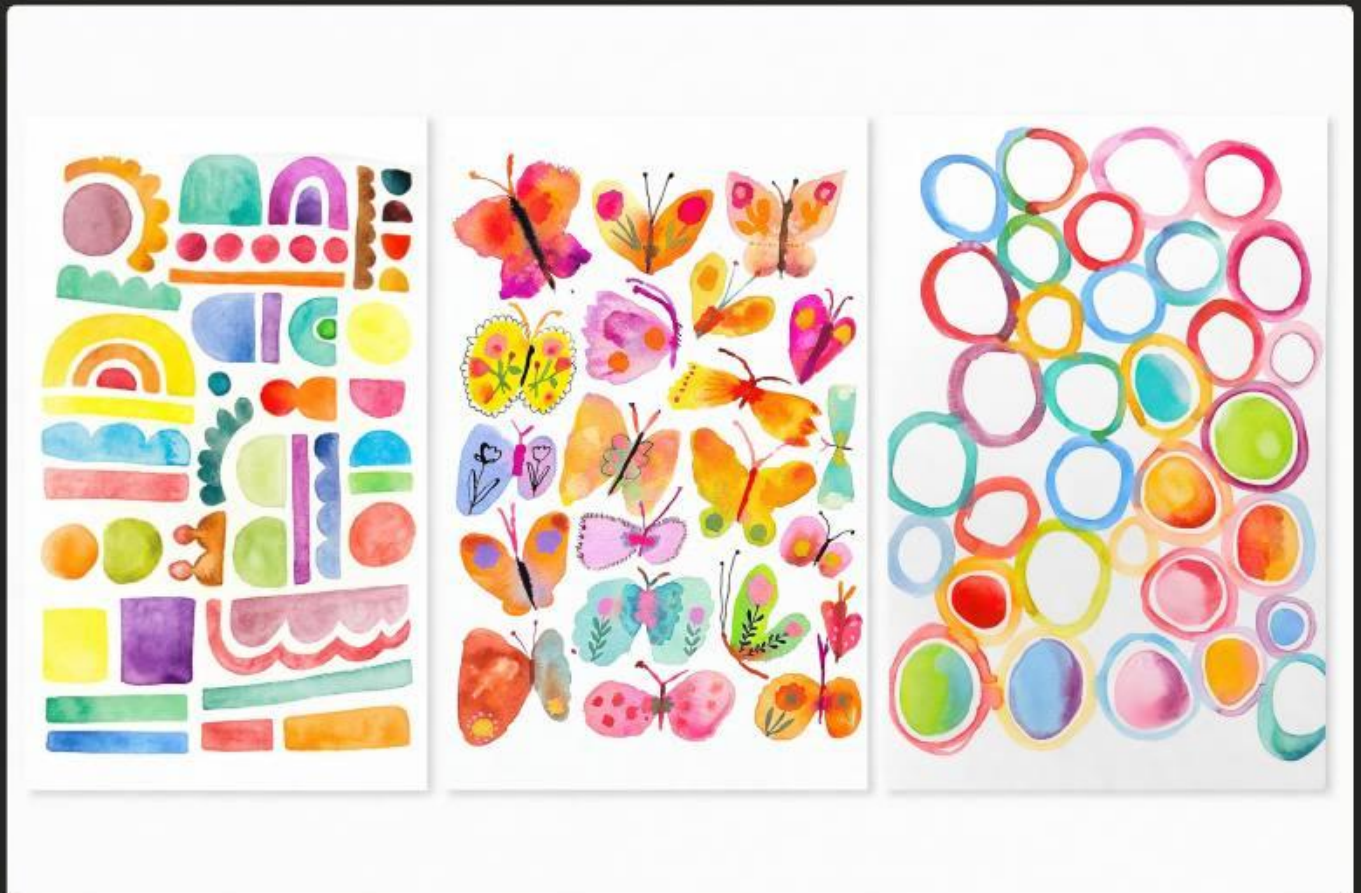
Encourage bold mixing – “*what happens if these two meet while wet?*” No ‘muddy’ – every mix is a discovery.

materials

acrylic paint · a brush · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

the fullest colour-mixing unit so far; the control here supports the deliberate painting that follows.



what we make – blended circles & shapes

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: planets · bubbles · a colour explosion

rainbow art

acrylic

the objective

Fill areas of the page with flat, bold, deliberate colour – clean edges and confident coverage.

skills it builds

colour & painting

the technique

Colour blocking – fill each area with even, solid colour right up to a clean edge, one colour at a time.

1. Sketch the areas lightly.
2. Fill each with flat, even colour to the edge.
3. Let colours meet crisply, not muddily.

why it's good for children

Colour blocking teaches **control and patience** – filling neatly to an edge is a real technical skill, and the bold result is hugely satisfying. It's the counterpart to blending: colour used with precision, not blur.

how to encourage them

Praise even coverage and clean edges. *"Take your time up to the line."*

materials

acrylic paint · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

pairs with abstract circles – precision after blending; both feed the still-life units ahead.



what we make – a bold rainbow

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a rainbow sky · a rainbow animal · rainbow stripes

fish

oil pastel

the objective

Draw a fish from one simple shape and layer colours for a shimmery surface.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Shape + shimmer – build the body from one pointed oval, layer blue, silver and yellow, and blend for iridescence; add marks for scales.

1. Draw one pointed oval for the body.
2. Layer blue, silver and yellow and blend for shimmer.
3. Press short marks for scales; add the eye and fins.

why it's good for children

A fish is a forgiving 'real' subject – one simple shape a child draws with confidence, which frees their attention for **colour**. Chasing the shimmer of a real fish makes children close observers.

how to encourage them

Put a real fish photo out – “*how many colours hide in one scale?*”

materials

oil pastels · paper · a fish photo

where it sits in the spiral

shape confidence built here supports the composition of the next unit.



what we make – one shimmering fish

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a big fish · a fish from the market · a rainbow fish

two fish

oil pastel

the objective

Overlap two fish so they swim together – an early taste of composition and depth.

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

the technique

Overlap & composition – draw one fish, then a second that crosses it, so one appears in front of the other.

1. Draw the first fish.
2. Add a second that overlaps it.
3. Colour both, keeping the front one clear.

why it's good for children

Overlapping quietly introduces **composition and depth** without ever naming it – children discover that where things sit changes the picture.

how to encourage them

"Let them swim together – which one is in front?"

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

turns single-shape confidence into a first real composition.



what we make – two fish swimming together

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: two fish · a small shoal · fish crossing paths

sea creatures

watercolour

the objective

Paint several simple sea creatures with bright washes to build a whole scene.

skills it builds

colour & painting

shape & form

the technique

Bright washes + simple shapes – build each creature from an easy shape and fill with clean, bright watercolour.

1. Sketch a few sea creatures as simple shapes.
2. Fill each with a bright watercolour wash.
3. Add legs, eyes and pattern once dry.

why it's good for children

Watercolour gives lively, luminous colour, and simple creatures let children build a **full scene** – their first taste of composing many elements on one page.

how to encourage them

"Who lives in your sea?" Encourage a busy, colourful world.

materials

watercolours · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

composing several elements; a bridge toward the collage scenes ahead.



what we make – a lively underwater world

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a crab and an octopus · a rock pool · a coral reef

whimsical creature

mixed media

the objective

Invent a creature by combining bold shapes, pattern and colour.

skills it builds

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Shape play + pattern – build a creature from simple shapes, then fill it with your own patterns and marks.

1. Build a creature from a few bold shapes.
2. Fill it with your own patterns.
3. Add eyes and details to bring it alive.

why it's good for children

Inventing frees **imagination** to lead – there's no wrong answer, which builds creative confidence, while filling with pattern grows fine control.

how to encourage them

"The sillier the better – what does yours do?"

materials

pens · oil pastel · paper

where it sits in the spiral

invention + pattern; sets up the collage creatures that follow.



what we make – an invented creature

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a friendly monster · a magic fish · a creature no one has seen

pigeon collage

mixed media

the objective

Build a real bird from cut and torn paper shapes, arranged with care.

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

the technique

Cut-paper composition – build the bird from a body, head, wing and tail cut from paper, arranging before gluing.

1. Cut a body, head, wing and tail.
2. Arrange them into a bird – move before gluing.
3. Glue down and add the eye and feet.

why it's good for children

Building a recognisable bird from separate shapes grows **shape awareness and composition** – children plan how parts fit into a whole.

how to encourage them

"Move the wing until it looks right, then glue."

materials

coloured paper · scissors · glue

where it sits in the spiral

cut-paper composition, a calmer companion to the painted-paper bird.



what we make – a bird built from paper

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a city pigeon · a garden bird · a flock

paul klee world

mixed media

the objective

Arrange shapes and colour to build a whole imaginary place, thinking about how the parts fit together (Paul Klee's style).

skills it builds

shape & form

balance & composition

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Composition + imagination – divide the page into shapes, colour them thoughtfully, and let the shapes suggest buildings, paths and places.

1. Divide the page into many shapes with lines.
2. Colour each shape, thinking about warm/cool and balance.
3. Let the shapes become a city or world.

why it's good for children

This is a real **composition** challenge – children think about the **whole page**, not one object, and how colours and shapes balance across it. Building an imaginary place keeps the abstract idea playful and personal.

how to encourage them

Show a Paul Klee painting. Ask “*which shape could be a house? a road?*” Praise interesting arrangements.

materials

oil pastel / watercolour · paper

where it sits in the spiral

a full-page composition unit; the whole-page thinking here carries into the harder scenes ahead.



what we make – an imaginary city or world

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a city of shapes · a castle world · a world under the sea

big fruit & ants

mixed media

the objective

Build a scene with deliberate size contrast – one huge object and tiny characters – to create drama and depth.

skills it builds

balance & composition

shape & form

the technique

Story composition – make one element very large and others very small, and place them so the size difference tells a story.

1. Make one fruit fill most of the page.
2. Add tiny ants or characters around it.
3. Arrange them so the big and small play off each other.

why it's good for children

Playing with **scale** is a powerful composition idea – children discover that size creates **drama and depth**, and that where you place things changes the whole feeling. The humour keeps a sophisticated idea joyful.

how to encourage them

Ask “what if the fruit was *ENORMOUS* and the ants were *tiny*?” Encourage a mini story.

materials

mixed media · paper

where it sits in the spiral

pushes composition with scale and story; balance skills here feed the harder painting units.



what we make – a giant-fruit scene

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a giant watermelon · a huge strawberry with ants · an enormous cake

animals in acrylic

acrylic

the objective

Reduce an animal to its most essential shapes, then paint it boldly – saying more with less.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Shape simplification – look past the detail to the few big shapes that make the animal, and paint those confidently.

1. Study the animal – find its 2-3 biggest shapes.
2. Paint those shapes boldly and simply.
3. Add only the few details that matter.

why it's good for children

Simplifying is a genuinely advanced idea – children learn to **see the big shapes** beneath the detail, which is how real artists and designers work. It builds confidence to make bold, decisive marks.

how to encourage them

Ask “if you only had three shapes, which would you keep?” Resist adding too much detail.

materials

acrylic paint · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

applies shape-and-form at a higher level; decisiveness here supports the composed still lifes next.



what we make – an animal from essential shapes

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a bold cat · a simple bird · a favourite animal

lemons & oranges 🍊

acrylic

the objective

Combine painted shapes with cut-paper detail to build a considered still life with light and arrangement.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Collage + paint – paint the fruit, then add cut-paper highlights and details, arranging the group across the page.

1. Paint the fruit shapes with blended colour.
2. Add cut-paper highlights and leaves.
3. Arrange the group with space and balance.

why it's good for children

Bringing two techniques together – **paint and collage** – asks children to plan and combine, a real step up in thinking. Arranging a group teaches **composition and balance** with a calm, classic subject.

how to encourage them

Set up a real bowl of citrus. Ask *"where should each one sit so it looks balanced?"*

materials

acrylic · coloured paper · glue · real citrus

where it sits in the spiral

combines earlier skills – colour, collage, composition – into one considered piece.



what we make – a citrus still life

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a bowl of citrus · a cut lemon · oranges on a table

flower pots 🎨

acrylic

the objective

Arrange a group of objects deliberately across the whole page, thinking about spacing, rhythm and balance.

skills it builds

balance & composition

colour & painting

the technique

Composition – place pots across the page with deliberate spacing and variety in size and colour so the whole page feels balanced.

1. Plan where the pots will sit across the page.
2. Vary their size, colour and flowers.
3. Paint them, keeping the spacing balanced.

why it's good for children

This is composition as the **main event** – children make deliberate choices about the whole page, the hallmark of maturing artists. Rhythm and repetition with variation is a rich, satisfying design idea.

how to encourage them

Ask “are they evenly spaced? does the page feel balanced?” Encourage variety within the row.

materials

acrylic paint · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

a dedicated composition unit; whole-page control here leads into the hardest units.



what we make – a row of flower pots

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a windowsill of pots · a market flower stall · pots big and small

robots

mixed media

the objective

Build a complex, invented character from many materials, making deliberate choices about every part.

skills it builds

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Construction + imagination – combine drawing, cut paper and found bits to build a robot, choosing each part on purpose.

1. Design the robot's body from boxes and shapes.
2. Add arms, dials, lights and details from different materials.
3. Give it a name and a job.

why it's good for children

Combining many materials into one character is **ambitious making** – it grows planning, problem-solving and deep **imagination**. Every choice (what does this part do?) makes the child a designer, not just a painter.

how to encourage them

Ask “*what is your robot for? what does each part do?*” Celebrate inventive choices.

materials

mixed media · found materials · glue

where it sits in the spiral

the fullest invention unit – brings together shape, material and story before the final unit.



what we make – an invented robot

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a helpful robot · a silly robot · a robot made of junk

eric carle bird

painted-paper collage

the objective

Paint textured paper, then tear and layer it to build a bird (Eric Carle's method).

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Painted-paper collage – paint whole sheets with texture, dry them, then tear shapes and layer them into a bird.

1. Paint several sheets in bright textures.
2. Once dry, tear body, wing and tail shapes.
3. Layer and glue them into a bird.

why it's good for children

Separating **making the colour** from **making the picture** lets children work big and bold, then compose calmly – a two-stage process that builds patience and planning.

how to encourage them

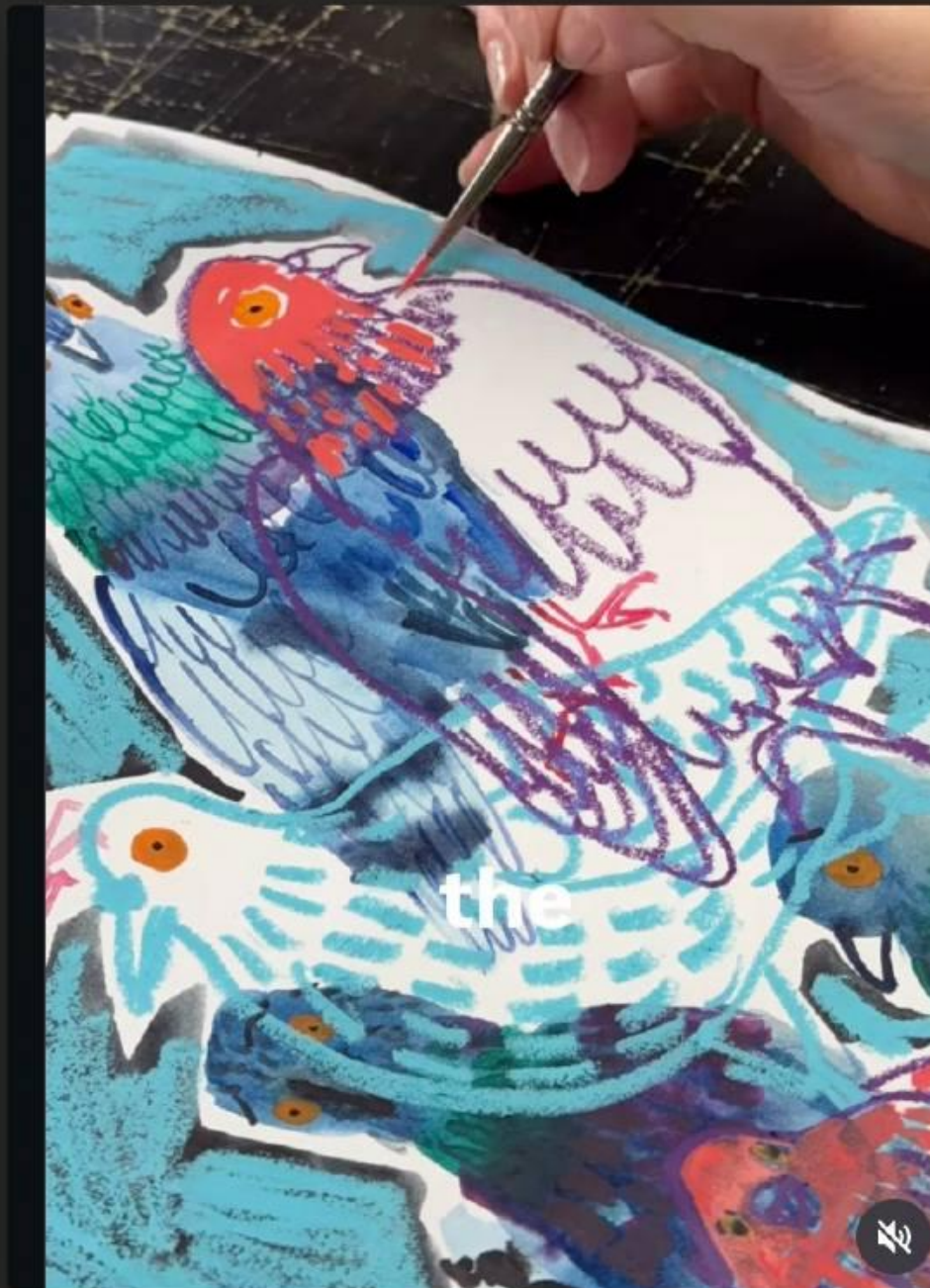
Show an Eric Carle spread. *"Fill the whole sheet first."*

materials

paint · paper to paint · glue · scissors

where it sits in the spiral

colour-making meets composition – the book's richest collage.



what we make – a bright bird from painted paper

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a parrot · a peacock · a bird of my own

firefly & dragonfly

acrylic on black paper

the objective

Work on a dark ground, building from dark to light with white and bright colours to make a glowing night scene.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Painting with light – on black paper, add light colours to make things appear to glow; a little light goes a long way against the dark.

1. Start on black paper – plan where the light will be.
2. Build glows with white and bright colours, softly.
3. Add the brightest highlights last, sparingly.

why it's good for children

Reversing the usual approach – **light on dark** – is the book's hardest and most magical idea. It asks children to think about **light itself**, plan a whole atmosphere, and hold back – the restraint of a real painter. A glowing result feels like magic they made.

how to encourage them

Ask “*where is the light coming from?*” Encourage restraint – “*the dark makes the light glow.*”

materials

acrylic · black paper · a fine brush

where it sits in the spiral

the book's peak – colour, composition and atmosphere together, on the hardest ground.



what we make – a glowing night scene

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: fireflies in a jar · a dragonfly at dusk · a glowing night pond